

Looking for a workhorse of a printer capable of churning out pages fast, in bulk and cheaply? We test 10 laser printers that cost less than Rs 30,000—Go ahead! Bring one home

When it comes to choosing a desktop-level laser printing solution, you must be asking yourself some questions. Like, will it fit my budget? Will it be able to print fast enough? What will the image quality be like? Well, these questions should not worry you much because laser printers have evolved from being bulky, unglamorous pieces of hardware lying in a remote corner in your office to aesthetically pleasing products that offer fast printing speeds and great image quality. Laser printers today are capable of crystal clear printouts at up to 100 pages per minute—ideal for situations where you need bulk printing at a continuous flow. To make the choice easier for you, we test 10 laser printers costing less than Rs 30,000.

Laser printers also have a number of advantages over other printing technologies—they produce superior quality documents (both text and graphics, in monochrome as well as colour) and the cartridges are also longer lasting compared to their inkjet counterparts. Couple this with the fact that you can use a laser printer over a network, and you have a cost-effective printing solution for applications where many users use a shared resource to print from.

Getting your hands on a printer of your choice should not be a big problem. Industry bigwigs such as HP, Samsung and Epson have kept the buyers interested with their impressive product line. What's more interesting is that together with overall quality, manufacturers have also started concentrating on small but nifty features such as the LCD display, the inclusion of the USB and the Parallel ports, the inclusion of a network port and paper tray holders with one-touch adjustments.

If you are still not convinced about buying a laser printer, we test 10 such printers under the Rs 30,000 mark. Go ahead and make your choice.

Digit Test Process

We tested the laser printers on a test machine comprising of a Pentium 4 running at 2.8 GHz on an Intel D850EMV2 motherboard with 256 MB of RDRAM. We used a GeForce3 chipset-based graphics card and a Seagate ATA 4, 40 GB, 7,200-rpm hard disk which was installed on the primary IDE channel. The monitor used was the Samsung 75E and a generic CD-ROM was used for installing the drivers. The hard drive was clean formatted and Windows XP was installed. The printer drivers were loaded on to the OS after connecting the printer under test. Once the test on each printer was completed, its drivers were uninstalled. The onboard USB port was used for all printers that featured the USB interface. For the image quality test, the resolution was kept at a default 600 dpi.

Test methodology

The printers were tested on four primary parameters: features (20 per cent weightage), performance (40 per cent), value for money (20 per cent) and warranty and support (20 per cent). The weightages allotted to each parameter was used to calculate the overall scores.

Features: We looked for usability features such as the type and number of buttons/controls, LCD display provided and indicators if any. We also checked the build quality and noted the default paper capacity. Another important feature was the toner price—we calculated the cost per page keeping in mind its estimated print life. Apart from this, we also considered the documentation provided by the manufacturers such as quick start guides and the comprehensiveness of the manuals and other documentation.

Performance: We evaluated the speed, quality and bulk printing efficiency. To test a printer's speed, we ran three tests. In the first test we printed

an image file three times and noted the average time taken. Next, to check the speed of text printouts, we recorded the time taken to print 50 pages of text in a Word document. Finally, we printed a Combi document in PDF format and the time taken to print a single page was noted. We also performed a bulk-printing test where we printed 50 pages of text and checked if there were any paper jams or multiple sheet printouts.

To test the quality of the printouts, we printed our test image file and a sectional analysis was done on the printout where we noted the level to which details were captured in pre-defined areas of the printout. This was done for both the image file as well as the Combi document. For checking the quality when printing text, we used a document containing text with varying font sizes. The sentence that we used contained all the alphabets from the English language in both upper and lower case. In this test we looked for any misaligned or blotchy text and awarded higher points to printouts that were accurate and readable.

Warranty and support: Here we looked for the type of warranty provided, the number years for which it's valid, the number of service centres present in the country and the number of cities in which they are present. We also checked if the warranty provided is comprehensive and whether a replacement is provided during the warranty period.



This greyscale image was used for testing the print quality of the laser printers. The image contains a good mix of fine details in different zones of the printable area. For instance, the area near the leaves gives a good indication of a printer's ability to pick up details